campaigns and motivational efforts to broaden public support. Some of it at least would be familiar to the ASEAN political culture.

Growing ties with ASEAN was initially described in India as our ‘Look East’ policy. To underline our seriousness in taking it forward, especially through physical connectivity projects, this was upgraded to ‘Act East’ a few years ago. This evolution also reflected its expanding security content. But whatever its name, this relationship actually reflects a profound shift in India’s geopolitical outlook towards the world to its East. Contacts and cooperation with South-East Asia opened up to India the world beyond it. This was around the time when India also sought to engage Japan, South Korea and China more seriously. There is no question that ASEAN was a conduit – psychologically, politically and perhaps even physically. In the years thereafter, as we entered the East Asia Summit process, this particular direction of India’s engagement strengthened even further and extends now to Australia and New Zealand as well as the Pacific Islands. Indeed, without ASEAN, the transformation of the Asia-Pacific to the Indo-Pacific would have never happened.

Developments over the last quarter century have brought out that the India-ASEAN engagement has actually unleashed ideas, interests and forces that none of us could have foreseen at that time. At its most basic level, the relationship with ASEAN has contributed to changing Indian thinking, of society as much as policymakers. Exposures and interactions have through osmosis raised new expectations and ambitions. Some of these are today very apparent in Indian policy activities and debates.

Quite apart from encouraging economic reforms, ASEAN has influenced Indian thinking on a broader set of issues. For a start, it has facilitated the externalization of India to a great degree. Indeed, the new wave of Indian investment abroad began in South-East Asia. Singapore, of course, is a vivid example. The involvement with the ASEAN and the consequent trade and sourcing of resources has also significantly heightened maritime consciousness. This has led India not only to be more active in the pursuit of maritime interests but to conceptualize that domain for policy engagement. A focused and integrated Indian Ocean policy today is largely shaped by its experiences with ASEAN. This interaction has also had a